Govt clears ₹4K cr VISTAR scheme to revamp India's statistical system



Wider net

- 59 surveys planned over five years, up from 43
- 8th Economic Census to count non-farm establishments and workers across India
- New services output and unincorporated sector indices planned
- AI, mobile, e-com data to strengthen surveys
- Census to create baseline for National Statistical Business Register and help measure unorganised sector's GDP share

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The Union Cabinet on Wednesday approved a ₹4,371.10 crore scheme to overhaul India's official statistical system, bringing all surveys, data, and economic census work of the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (Mospi) under one umbrella for five years, spanning from financial year 2026-27 (FY27) to FY31.

The Viksit Bharat Initiative for Statistical Transformation, Analytics & Research (VISTAR)— cleared at the Cabinet meeting chaired by Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi — will fund 59 surveys over the 16th Finance Commission cycle (FY27-FY31) to fill "critical data gaps in various sectors", compared to 43 major surveys conducted previously. The initiative also bankrolls the long-delayed 8th Economic Census and a revamped programme for support to state statistical bureaus.

"Aligned with the central objective of Viksit Bharat 2047, the VISTAR scheme is designed to establish a dynamic, real-time and future-ready official statistical architecture for enhanced timeliness, data granularity, (and) interoperability with harmonised and AI-ready datasets," said a statement issued by the government.

The scheme has three components: comprehensive statistical operations and strengthening of the ecosystem; support for statistical strengthening (SSS) for states; and the economic census.

Under the first component, Mospi will digitise statistical processes and embed artificial intelligence (AI) and machine learning (ML) in data processing, validation, and analysis.

The ministry plans some new measures, including a Headline Index of Services Production and an Index of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises. It will also tap alternative sources such as mobile phone, scanner, and e-commerce data to complement traditional surveys and ease the burden on respondents.

Mopsi released a trial Index of Services Production covering 19 sub-sectors in July this year, but the headline index, a single composite index, is yet to be launched.

In a briefing after the meet, Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said the PM had always stressed "objective data collection" and "a systematic and methodical statistical system". "We must move beyond the long-standing attitude of merely continuing as before and conduct thorough investigation, thorough analysis, and examine matters carefully. Decisions should then be made on that basis," he said, adding that the scheme will essentially revamp the country's entire statistical system and give it new strength.

Under a redesigned Support for Statistical Strengthening framework, dubbed SSS 2.0, central funds to states and Union Territories will be "deliverable-linked". Mospi will help scale up district-level and million-plus city estimates in flagship surveys, such as the Periodic Labour Force Survey, and assist in compiling state and district gross domestic product (GDP).

The 8th Economic Census, to be conducted with the states, will count all non-farm establishments and their workers down to gram panchayat and ward level. It will form the baseline for a National Statistical Business Register, and help estimate the unorganised sector's share of GDP.

The nod caps a year of rebasing at Mospi. In February, the ministry released a new Consumer Price Index series with 2024 as base year, followed by a GDP series with 2022-23 as base, replacing the 2011-12 series. A new Index of Industrial Production was also launched in June on a 2022-23 base.

"With attention to data collection, surveys, bias reduction, data validation, and ground-truthing, statistics will gain new prestige," Vaishnaw said.